

TV-TUNERS

The launch of Vista this year saw the 2007 saw Windows Media Center—which depends on compliant TV-Tuners to turn your PC into an entertainment centre—reach everyone, rather than just people who bought Media Center PCs. We tested TV-Tuners in three categories: Internal PCI, External USB, and External Set-top, the first being the most popular as far as Desktop PCs are concerned. We also saw the first digital TV-Tuners making an appearance, though we didn't test them; the availability of digital terrestrial broadcasts is very limited. We will probably see more of these next year; digital broadcast is expected to grow.

INTERNAL PCI TV-TUNER CARDS

The Reigning Champion Leadtek WinFast PVR2000

This was one of a kind amongst the internal PCI TV-Tuners. It was the only one to feature an MPEG-2 decoder chip (which offloads the CPU from the task of encoding video while capturing). This TV-Tuner is Windows MCE and Vista MC ready. It sports the Conexant CX23882-39 chip, which is known to deliver superior picture quality owing to the 10-bit ADC. It supports the PAL and NTSC TV standards with stereo audio. The full-function remote gives you complete control over the TV card, thanks to the superb WinFast PVR software.

The Contender Leadtek Winfast TV2000 XP Global

This model is just a few steps behind the PVR2000 in terms of features, and is therefore priced lower (Rs 2,500). Features include FM radio, Picture-in-Picture, and a

remote control that can control the Media Player in Windows. In our tests, its performance was as good as that of the PVR2000.

The Award Leadtek WinFast PVR2000

The Zero1 award winner in this category, the Leadtek WinFast PVR2000 managed to detect-



ed weak TV channels during our tests. The driver installation is simple, and the PVR interface is very easy to understand and use. Picture quality was top-notch. It comes with a good software bundle, which makes it even more worthwhile to spend that Rs 5,500 on this card.

EXTERNAL USB TV-TUNERS

The Reigning Champion Leadtek WinFast PalmTop TV

Now here's an external USB TV-Tuner that looks good enough to adorn your desktop. This was the only external TV-Tuner to feature an MPEG-2 encoder. It has out-of-the-box support for Windows MCE and is Vista MC ready.

The Contenders Compro VideoMate Action Pro

This one is, without a doubt, the most rugged of external TV-Tuners, with a strong metallic casing. It was one of the



only three tuners to have a Composite port, which lets you hook up a camcorder so you can transfer analogue video recordings and get them converted into digital video. It comes bundled with all the necessary cables. In this category, it detected the highest number of cable TV channels, and didn't even require fine-tuning. The video quality was as good as that of the WinFast PalmTop TV.

The Award Leadtek WinFast PalmTop TV

Only the lack of certain features cost the Compro VideoMate Action Pro the Zero1 award. As for the Leadtek WinFast PalmTop TV, which is our winner, the included PVR software



has all the capabilities you might expect. The remote can be used to control everything. The tuner comes with a rich bundle of software, which includes WinFast PVR, CyberLink PowerDVD, Orb, Ulead's Cool 3D, DVD MovieFactory 3SE, and VideoStudio 9 SE DVD. And finally, the image quality was the best we've seen thus far with an external USB TV-Tuner.

EXTERNAL SET TOP TV-TUNERS

The Reigning Champion AVerMedia AVerTV Box7

AVerMedia has been the dominant player for the past many years as far as external set-top TV-Tuners are concerned, and it has remained that way. The AVerTV Box7 is way ahead of

the competition in terms of performance and its advanced features. It is the most rugged of the lot; it comes with a stand to keep it upright.

The Contender Tech-Com SSD-TV-722

This TV-Tuner has most of the features you would expect, and is reasonably priced at Rs 1,750. Useful features include Picture-in-Picture, which can be controlled via the



remote. The Tech-Com SSD-TV-722 comes with an MMI (MultiMedia Interface) cable for video and audio inputs from external sources such as DVD players. It supports a healthy viewing resolution of 1280 x 1024. It detected 84 out of 90 channels—not bad—and image quality was quite decent too.

The Award AVerMedia AVerTV Box7

The Zero1 in this category must go to the AVerMedia AVerTV Box7; it was well ahead of the competition, detecting 88 channels out of 90. None of its competitors came close to it as far as image quality goes, even though some



featured similar resolutions. It supports a resolution of up to 1280 x 1024. It has all types of connectors, enabling you to connect any AV source—even your set-top box. It's priced a wee bit on the higher side, but this is as close to TV as you can get on a monitor!